electoral year, and the continuation and outbreak of fighting on various fronts, a (partial) Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement (NCA) was signed less than a month prior to the elections, on 15 October 2015. Eight EAGs signed the NCA, while others were not allowed to participate, and more abstained from signing for this reason.[4] The signing ceremony had been preceded by a first agreement on a draft ceasefire text on 31 March, but negotiations continued for another six months.[5]

During all this time, the peace negotiations were largely disconnected from the electoral process. Although President Thein Sein repeatedly called on all sides to work towards both peaceful elections and an NCA, the processes had no visible institutional links on the side of state agencies. Both the UEC and the Myanmar Peace Center (MPC) — entrusted with the facilitation of ceasefire negotiations on behalf of the Union Peacemaking Working Committee (UPWC) — were careful to stay within the boundaries of their respective mandates (see Su Mon Thazin Aung, this volume). The UEC had some encounters with EAGs, but did not appear to pursue contact as part of a broader policy. Opportunities for convergence of the two processes were not explicitly pursued. For example, it could have been conceivable to tie agreements for ceasefire monitoring mechanisms to arrangements for electoral security, but this did not occur, partly because the NCA was agreed much later than initially expected — and too late to have a substantive impact on the electoral process.

This is not to say that the electoral and peace processes were unrelated. In an interview conducted in February 2014, chief negotiator Minister U Aung Min had already expressed concerns that the window of opportunity to reach a conclusive agreement would be closing ahead of national elections. Indeed, for much of 2015, elections were perceived to disrupt the longer-term peace negotiations, which were in principle open ended. Unlike in other countries where a brokered peace deal set the timing for elections, in Myanmar the electoral time frame was constitutionally mandated. At the same time, the raised stakes of the peace process created risks in the security environment ahead of the polls. Outbursts of violence occurred before or between crucial negotiation meetings, in particular in Kachin State and northern Shan State. Perceptions that violence preceded key meetings possibly as a deliberate strategy may have deepened the trust deficit in the talks.

It can be tempting to paint the potential electoral interests of ethnic armed actors and their relationships with political parties in black and